

Sexual identity, lexical association, and the ideological marking of place in San Francisco

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Agenda

Place identity

Rapid and anonymous survey

Neighborhood categorization

Lexical priming effects

Adequation and differentiation

Place and identity

Place is composed of

- a physical space
- the people who occupy it physically and symbolically

Place and identity are mutually reinforcing:

- Person-types are believed to inhabit a place
- The ideological composition of a place informs residents' identities



Social dimensions of place

Place identity does not exist in isolation

- Places are marked relative to their sociocultural landscape
- What social dimensions are relevant when constructing place?



The Marina

Class



The Mission

Ethnicity



The Castro

Sexuality

Place identity as relational

We can relate places to one another through **adequation** and **distinction**

Neighborhood A:

Urban
Working Class

Pred. Latino

Neighborhood B:

Rural
Working Class
Pred. Latino

Neighborhood C:

Rural
Wealthy

Pred. Latino

Places often become categorically marked for sexuality

- The “gayborhood” or “gay ghetto” essentialized by (non-normative) sexuality
- Other areas typically unmarked w.r.t. (normative) sexuality

How is sexuality lexically characterized relative to other social dimensions that constitute place?

Field sites

The **Castro** District

- San Francisco's predominant gayborhood and an international symbol of the city as a "gay mecca."

The **Mission** District

- A major Latino neighborhood in San Francisco, where Latinos made up 32% of the population in 2022 (8% in the Castro and 7% in the Marina).

The **Marina** District

- An affluent waterfront neighborhood with a reputation for being overwhelmingly white and normative.



**Quick, how would you describe
_____ in one word?**

What about _____?

Rapid anonymous survey

Background

- Originally used to analyze a single sociolinguistic variable
- **Our goal:** elicit ideologies about these three neighborhoods
- Double prompt invites place comparison
 - Lexical priming effects
- Each field site was chosen to explore particular contrasts

Elicitation Sites

- **Castro** x 2 → **gay sexuality**
 - Residential area on weekday afternoons, or **residents**
 - Commercial strip on weekend nights, or **visitors**
- **Mission** → **diverse ethnicities**
- **Marina** → **normative sexuality**

Data sample

- 4 field sites
- 638 participants
- 1276 responses

preppy
fun
bad
unique
stale
i_don't_go_there_a_lot_north_point_great_views_golden_gate_bridge
lively
lacking
cold
i_can't_give_you_an_answer
diverse
vibrant
bougie
white_(can_i_say_that?)
vibrant
i_don't_know_i_have_not_been_there_for_a_long_time
fun
open
beautiful
fabulous

Annotation schemes

Clean responses →

- Reduced all raw responses to a single word
- Simplified redundant lexemes to a single form (e.g., restaurant & restaurants → restaurant)

Thematic analysis →

- Clean responses were sorted into one of 24 categories
- Semantic similarity and valence-arousal scores when appropriate
- Similar responses were iteratively grouped; groups later named

Annotation schemes

Response	Clean Response
gay	gay
preppy	preppy
fun	fun
bad	bad
unique	unique
stale	stale
i_don't_go_there_a_lot_north_point_great_views_golden_gate_bridge_dating_scene_millennial	antitask
lively	lively
lacking	lacking
cold	cold
i_can't_give_you_an_answer	antitask
bougie	bougie
white_(can_i_say_that?)	white

Clean responses (👉)

Gay

gay, queer, fabulous, pride, rainbow, flamboyant, love, gayborhood, fruity, homosexuales, zesty, faggy, camp, lgbtqxyz, faggots

Sexual

slut, frisky, fucking, sexual, slutty, naked, bountiful

Fun (+valence > 0.7, +arousal > 0.7)

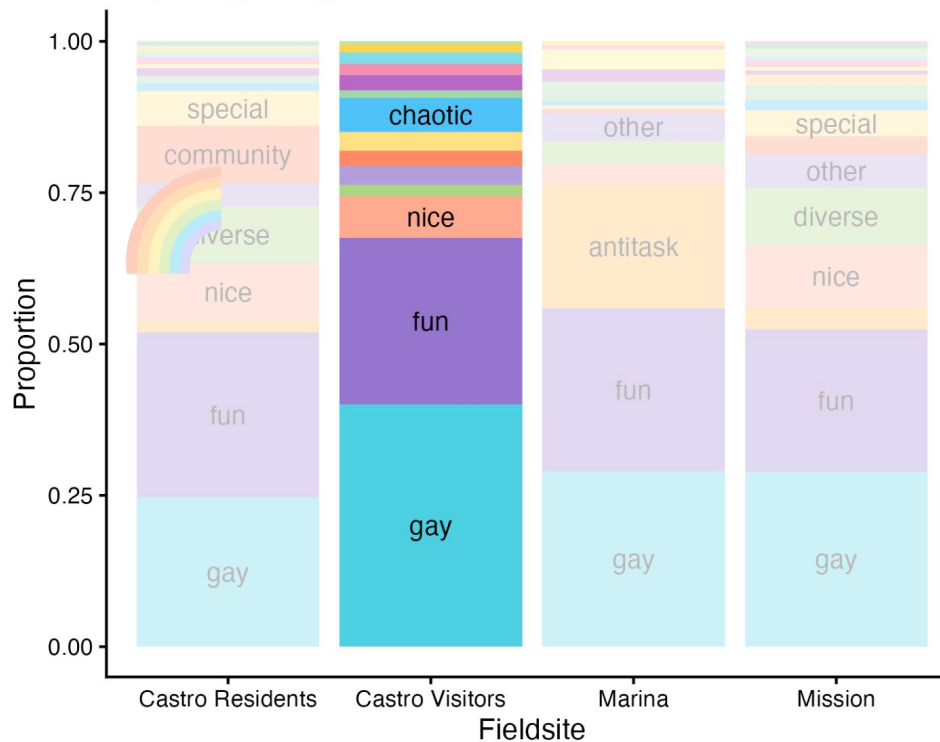
fun, vibrant, lively, wonderful, amazing, active, festive, great, fantastic, excelente, exciting, awesome, energetic, party, dance, buzzy, spanky, poppin, exuberant, funner, lit, espectaculo, joy, cunt, effervescent, entertaining, invigorating, delightful, joyous, electric, fun-loving, dynamic, expressive, stunning, best

Thematic analysis (🏳️)

How do people characterize the Castro?

Castro Responses by Fieldsite

Only categories greater than 4% receive labels



Across Field Sites:

- **Gay** is the most common response
- **Fun** is also common

Castro Visitors:

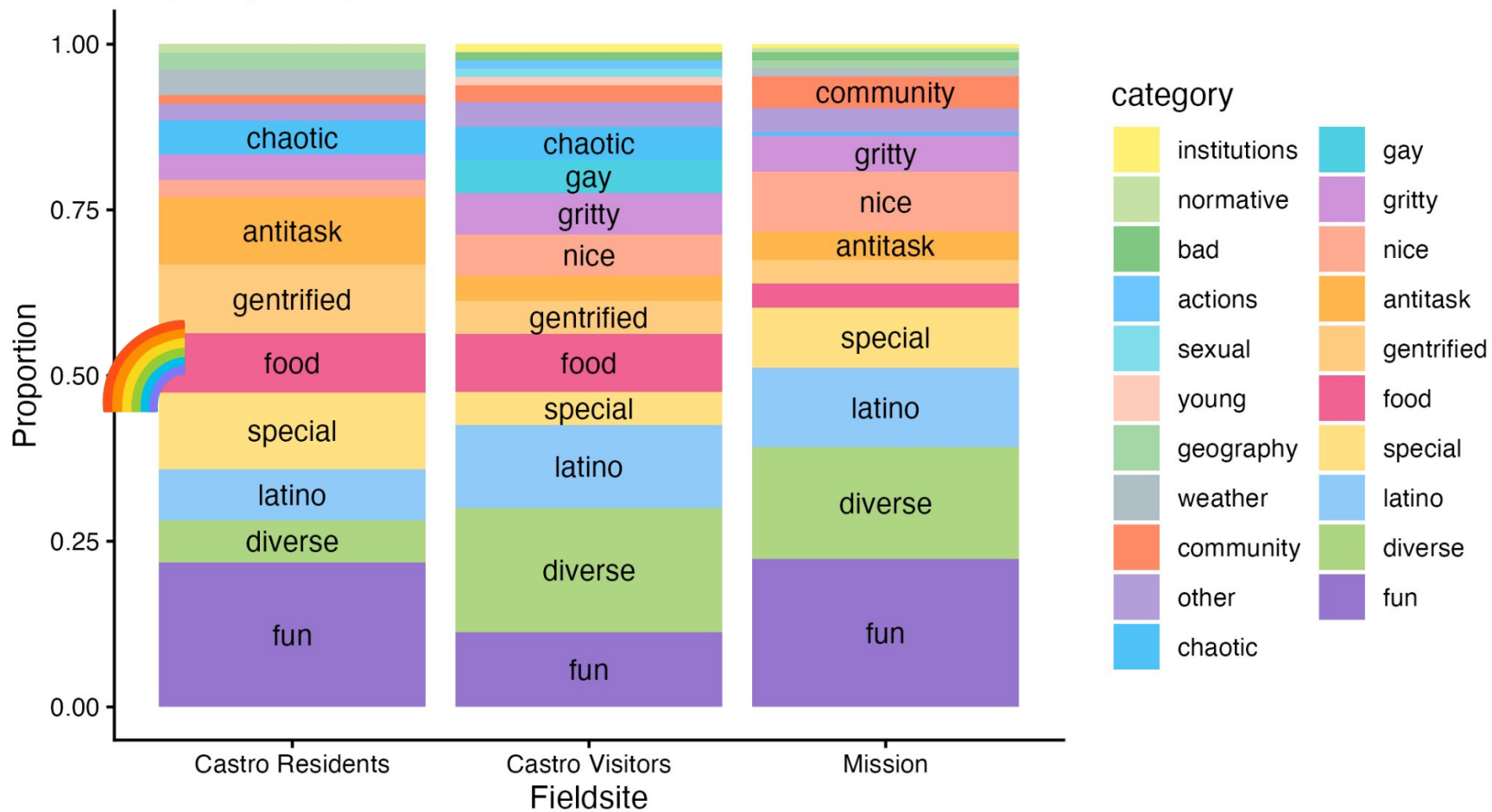
- use **gay** more than every other participant group

Castro Residents vs. Visitors:

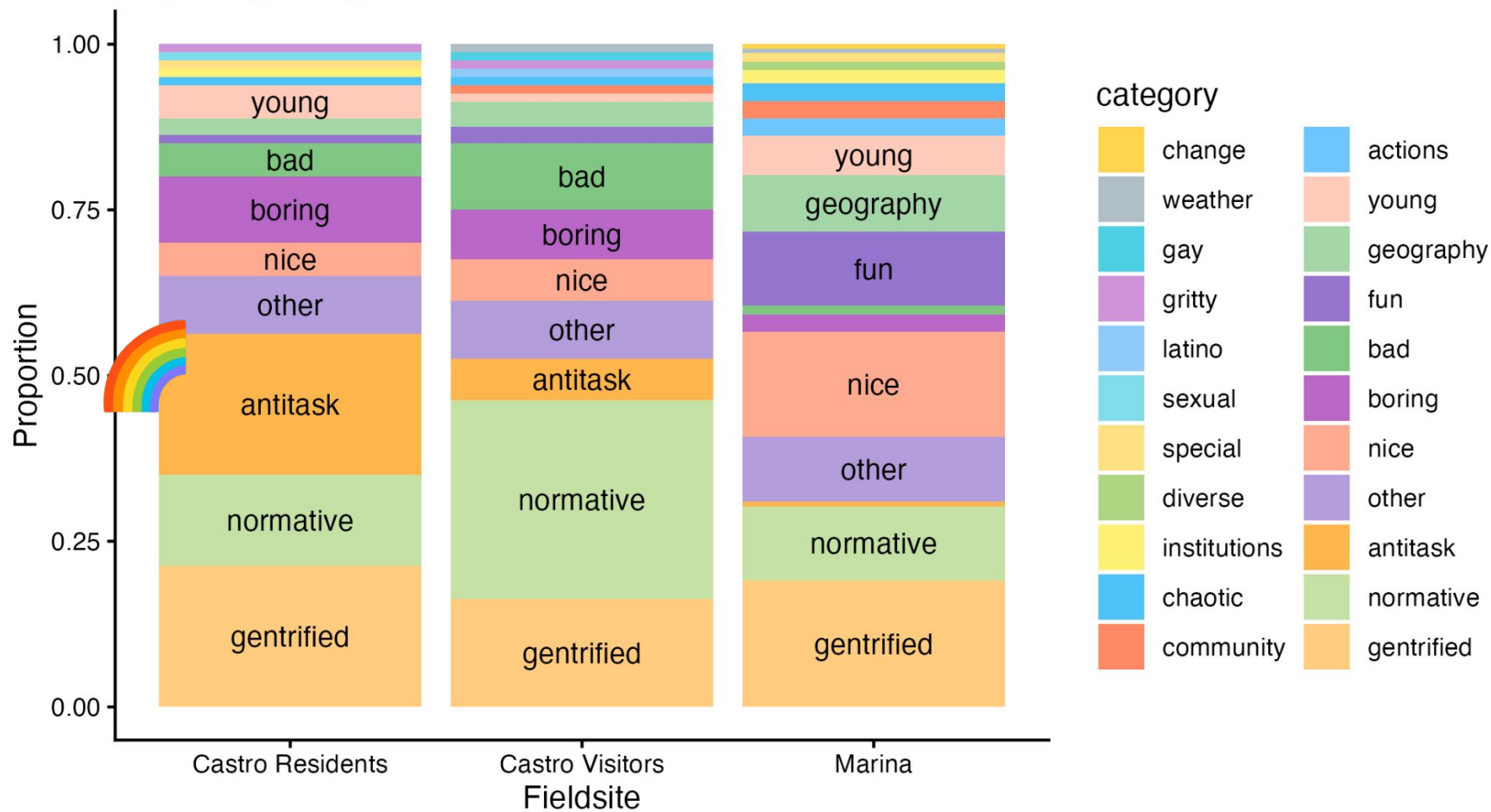
- Visitors say more **chaotic**
- Residents say more **community**

Mission Responses by Fieldsite

Only categories greater than 4% receive labels



Only categories greater than 4% receive labels



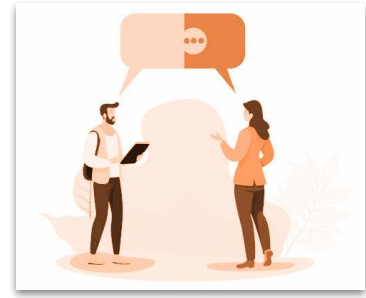
**Participants describe the Marina
as “straight” in 3.2% of
responses...**

**But only when asked about the
Castro first.**

Lexical priming effects

Every participant produced two neighborhood characterizations

Second response implicitly invites **comparison** between neighborhoods



Quick! Describe “**Response Site 1**”!

● [Response 1]

What about “**Response Site 2**”?

● [Response 2]

Lexical priming effects: bigram metrics

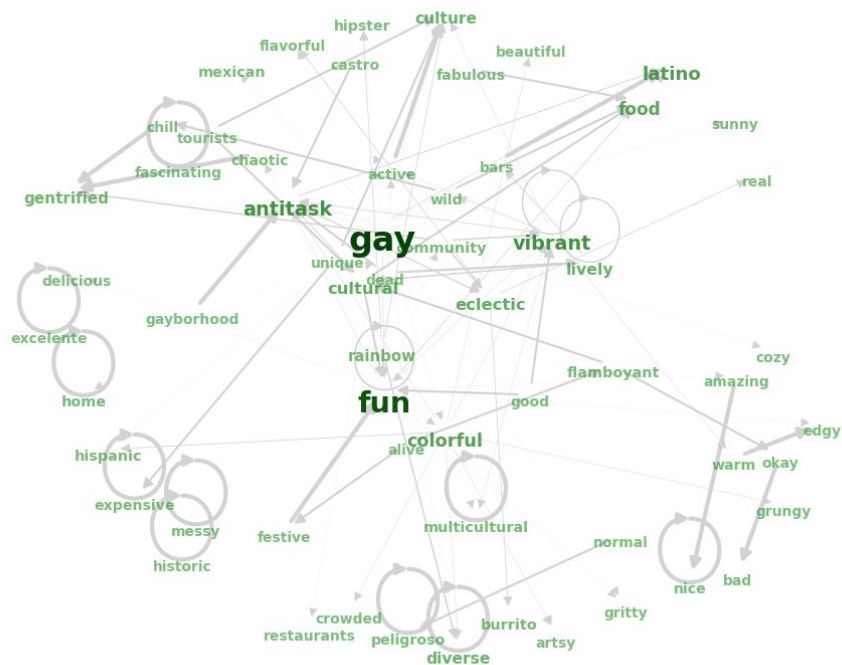
Forward probability = $P(W2 | W1)$

How does the first response predict the second response?

Backward probability = $P(W1 | W2)$

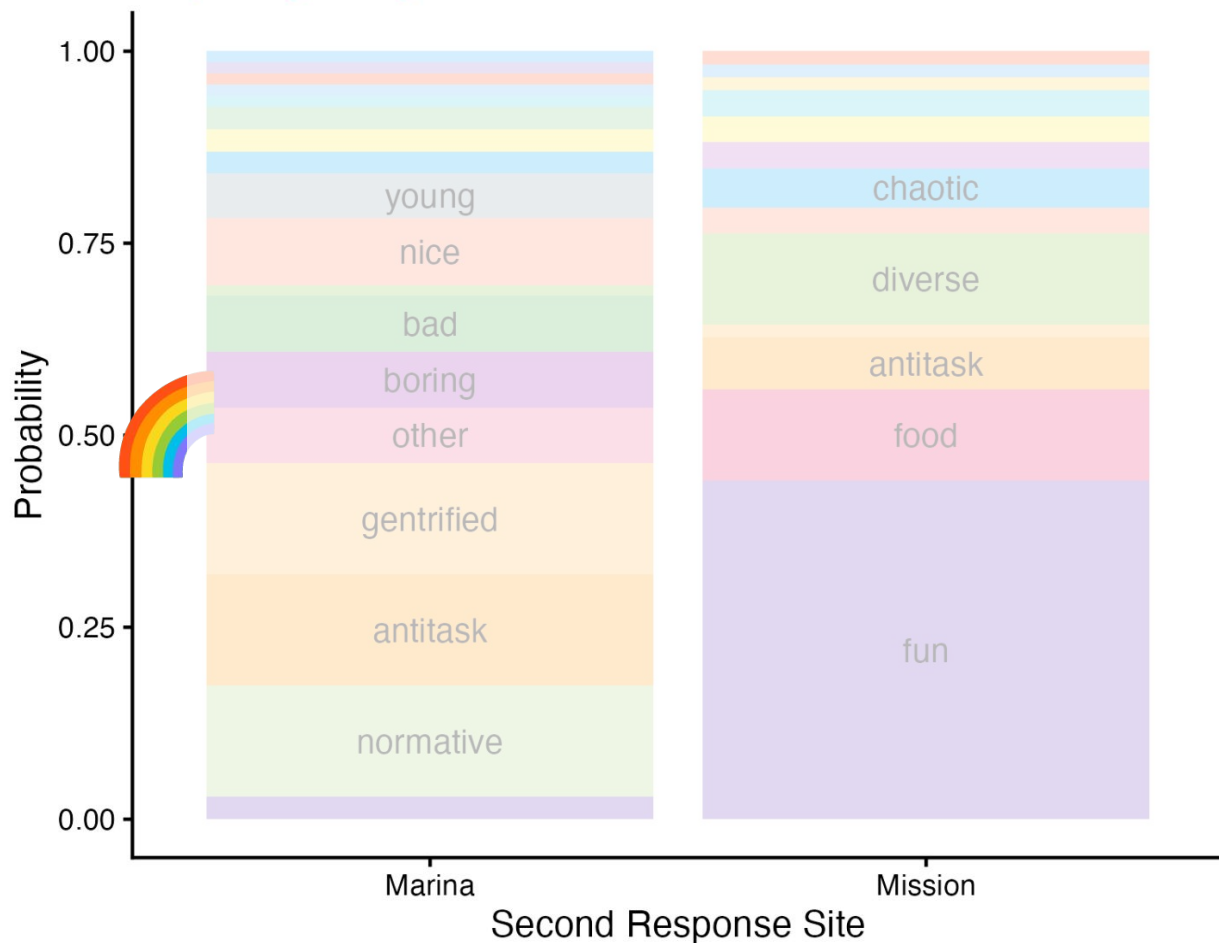
How does the second response constrain the first response?

Forward probabilities when Castro is first and Marina is second



When 'fun' describes the Castro first...

Only categories greater than 4% receive labels

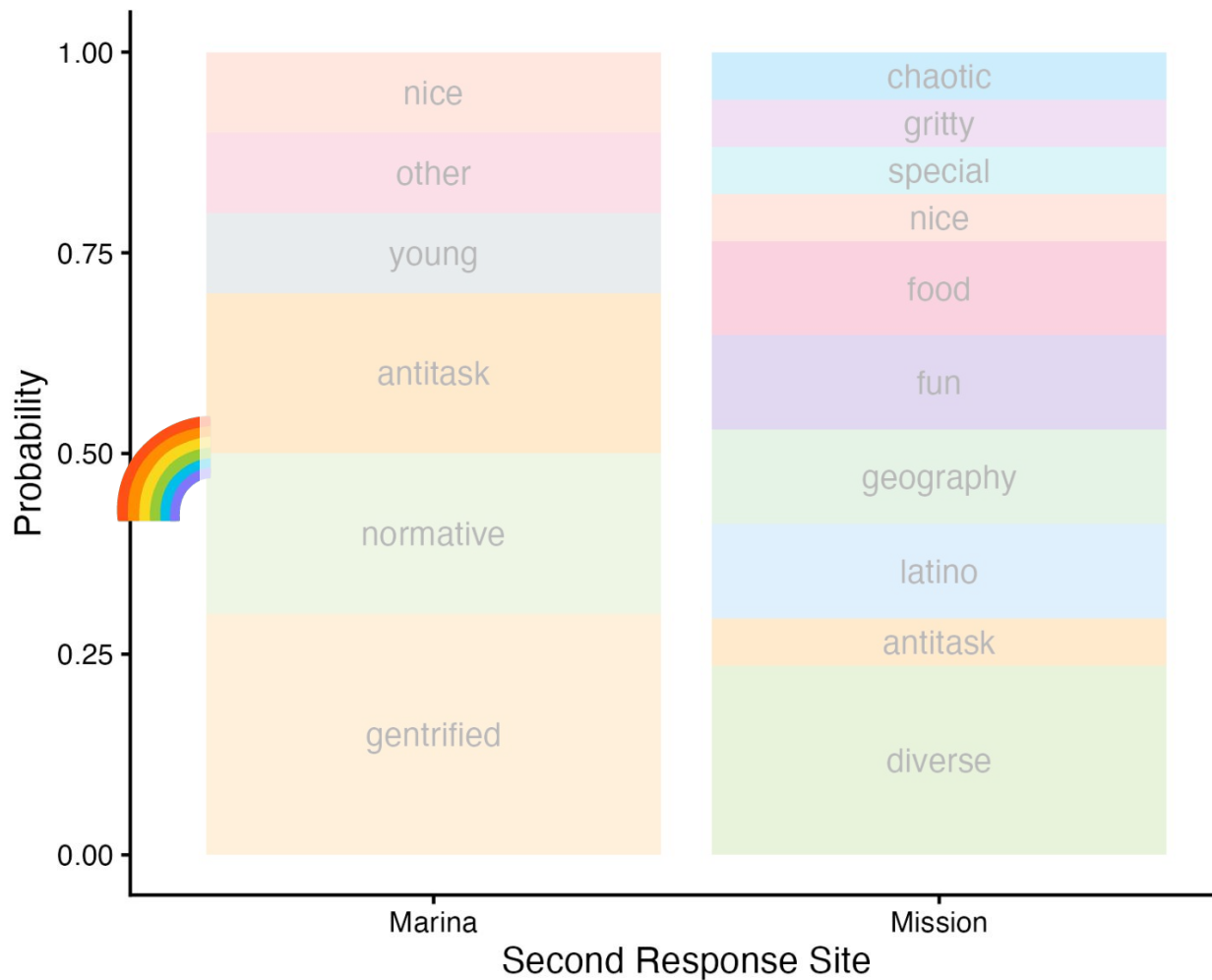


Second Response

Mission: fun is much more likely than expected

Marina: fun is slightly less likely than expected

When 'diverse' describes the Castro first...



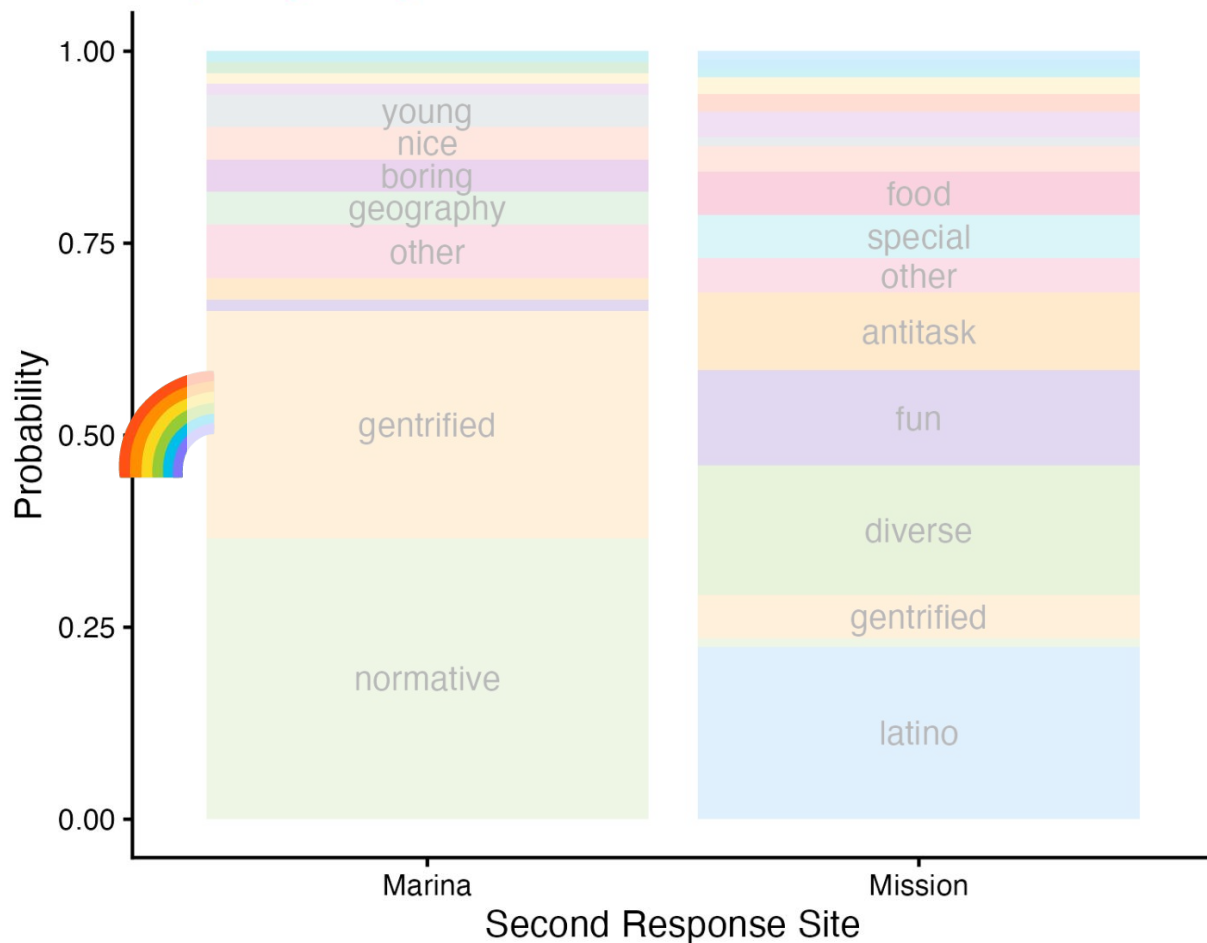
Second Response

Mission: **diverse** is more likely than expected

Marina: **gentrified** is more likely than expected

When 'gay' describes the Castro first...

Only categories greater than 4% receive labels

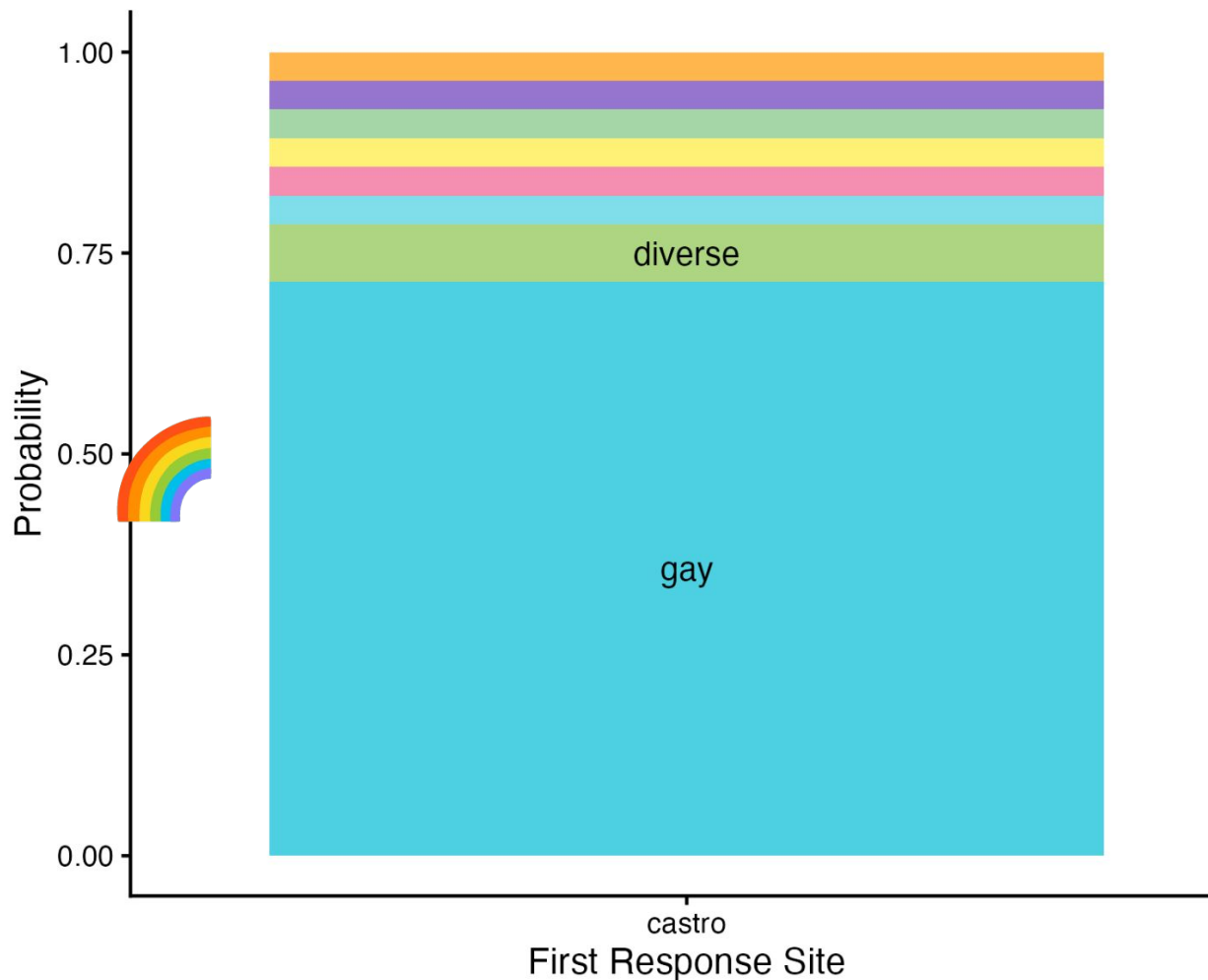


Second Response

Mission: latino is more likely than expected

Marina: normative and **gentrified** more likely than expected

When 'Latino' describes the Mission second...

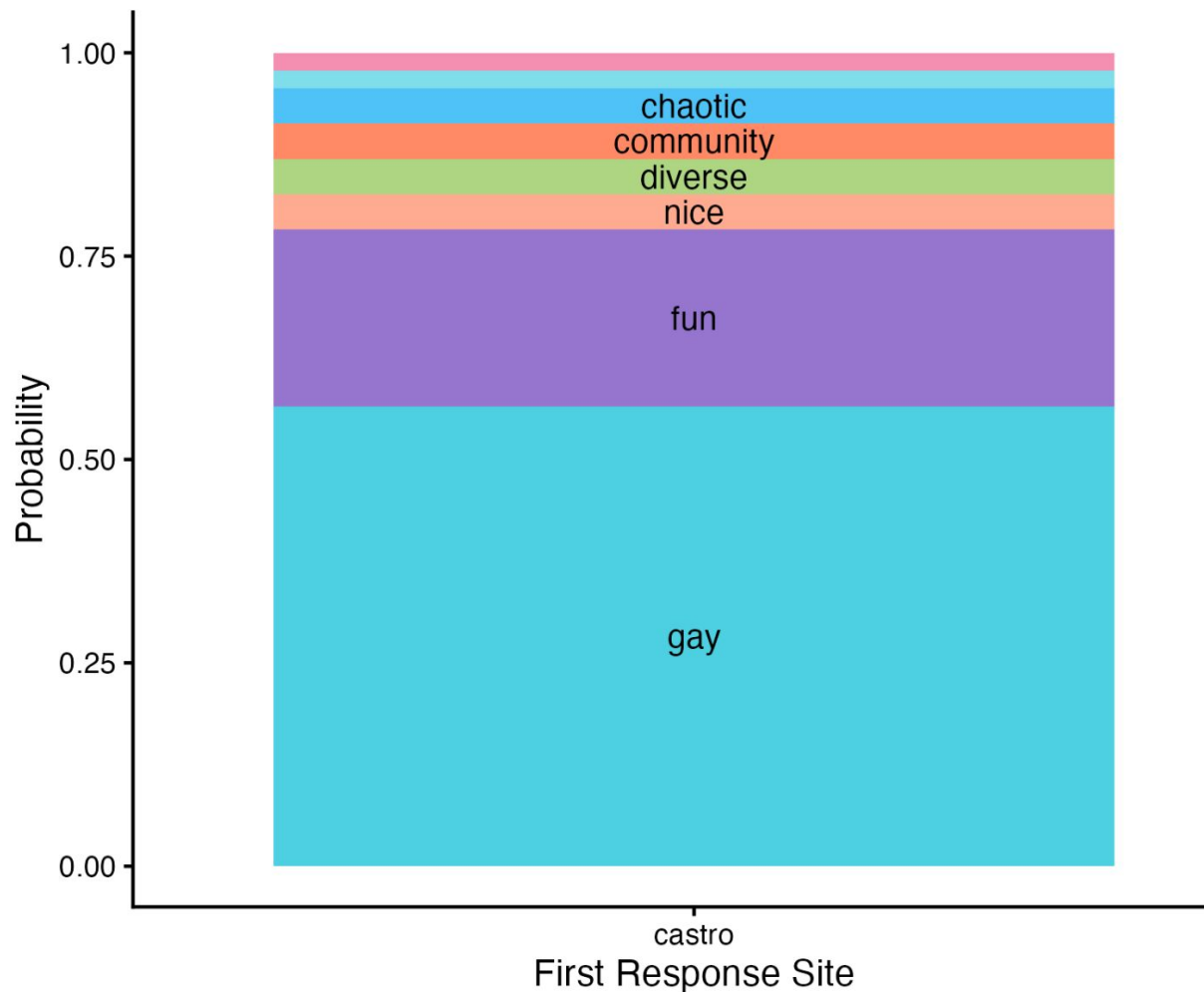


First Response

Gay predominates, **fun** or **nice** are much less common

The Mission's latinidad is **adequated** to **the Castro's** gayness

When 'normative' describes the Marina second...



First Response

Gay is much more common, **fun** less so

The Marina's normativity is **differentiated** from **the Castro's** gayness

Differentiation

About the Castro and Marina

- If Castro is associated with **gay** or **diverse**, Marina is associated with **normative** and **gentrified**
- If Castro is associated with **fun** diverse associations with Marina (not fun).

	Marina	
Castro First	Gay → Normative	

Adequation

About the Castro and the Mission

- If Castro is associated with **gay** or **diverse**, Mission is associated with **diverse** and **latino**
- If Castro is associated with **fun**, Mission is associated with **fun**

	Marina	Mission
Castro First	Gay → Normative	Gay → Latino

Conclusion

The Marina is distinguished as normative

- Marked for normative sexuality through differentiation
- Neighborhoods **can** be marked for normative sexuality
- Via normative social dimensions that clash with non-normativity
 - Despite the Castro sharing in some of these dimensions

The Castro and the Mission are jointly constructed as diverse

- Through the adequation of non-normativity
- Via (non-normative) sexuality and (non-normative) ethnicity
 - Despite differences in other social dimensions

Social dimensions (race, sexuality, class, etc.) **are bundled together in service of local contrasts** (normativity)

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